

Category	Android	Apple iOS
Approx number of apps	600,000+	500,000+
Hack attempts on Top 75 paid apps (%)	96%	92%
Hack attempts on Top 15 free apps (%)	80%	40%
Marketplace/App Store	Unregulated by Google	Strictly regulated by Apple
Malicious apps	Google Bouncer screens for such apps	Apple has a regulation mechanism in place, no specific software for malicious apps
Protection from Web-based attacks	Yes	Yes
Data encryption	Average	Excellent
User authentication for Apps	Yes	Yes
Remote erase	Yes, but via third-party apps only	No
Permissions	Granted while downloading	Granted while using for the first time
Approx market share	59%	20%

The above numbers will give you a fair idea of the security settings on each operating system. Having done that, let us head to the practical aspects.

Some practical examples

As the above table already tells you, Android lets you grant apps permissions before you actually download them. Apple iOS, on the other hand, lets you do the same when you run the app for the first time. So, what if you accidentally download an app that is, well, evil? In iOS, you will have that app lying dormant until you actually run it, and as a result, that app will have all the time in the world to harm you. Android apps, on the other hand, are required to inform you about the permission settings that they seek even before they are downloaded, and if you are not happy with the security settings, you can easily choose not to install such apps in the first place. Don't trust me? Consider this: both Android and iOS users once encountered certain apps that asked for a lot of user data. Fifty-four per cent of Android users actually refused to even install those apps, whereas as many as 79 per cent of iOS users ended up installing them (only to uninstall them later, when they found out about the security settings upon first launch of the apps).

What about the screening mechanism? Every iOS user tells you that the Apple App Store is more secure than Google Play, right? Here is another example: The Telegraph UK

once reported an incident related to an app named InstaStock created by Charlie Miller. The app served the purpose of providing the users with stock prices, market trends and other business related stuff. However, Miller later showed that the app could also access the users' photos and contacts, and even transmit them to a remote device, without informing the user! This app was approved by Apple initially, downloaded by a good million users, and later when Miller exhibited the flaw in his app, Apple pulled back the app, and terminated Miller's developer account. So, a developer shows the heart to challenge the security settings and break the myths related to iOS, and Apple banishes him! I wouldn't argue for or against what Miller did, but the moral of the story is—the Apple App Store is secure only on paper.

So, is Android more secure? In one word: yes. How? Let me explain.

It is true that Android faces more hack attempts and malicious attacks than iOS. Yet, that is because it is a more popular OS. Consider this: which has more viruses -- Windows, Linux or BSD? The answer is obvious. However, unlike the others, Android is open to third-party management tools for security, and thus, with a proper security settings level, you can easily make your Android device bullet-proof.

Before I actually conclude the article, I shall cite another case study. Apple iOS devices have less malicious attacks in terms of numbers, but whatever little share of attacks they get are way more serious in nature compared to the ones against Android. As AdaptiveMobile once reported, iOS is the least secure platform when it comes to basic things such as sending an SMS.

However, even Android is not a divine creation, and you need to exercise caution: download apps that are from trusted developers (the G+ ratings and community feedback are an excellent way to judge the credibility of a developer). Furthermore, make sure you read the permission details carefully, and use mobile banking only via the official apps. Last but not the least, stay away from those cash prize links in emails and apps. 

References

- Symantec.com <http://bit.ly/3Eb1K>
- The Telegraph UK <http://www.telegraph.co.uk/technology/apple/8878408/Rogue-iPhone-app-banned-from-iTunes-store.html>
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